VITALITY 17

Yohimbine

Alkaloid from the bark of the African yohimbe tree; an alpha-adrenergic receptor blocker



CLASS
Plant alkaloid

STUDIED FOR
Erectile dysfunction

HUMAN EVIDENCE
Controlled human trials (small, 1987–1998)

US STATUS
Not FDA approved · bark sold as supplement

STUDIED FOR

- Erections — HUMAN
- Sexual function — HUMAN

Trials are small and old. All were yohimbine hydrochloride tablets, before PDE5 drugs were approved. No trial of yohimbe supplements for ED was found.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Yohimbine ▶ Alpha receptors ▶ Vessels & arousal ▶ Erections

- **Blocks alpha-adrenergic receptors**, part of the nervous system that controls vessels
- That action is the **basis for its study** in erectile dysfunction
- **Bark supplements** may not act like the drug; their yohimbine content varies widely

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

CONTROLLED TRIALS
LEVEL 4 OF 5

- Placebo-controlled trials of 22 to 100 men
- Mixed results; meta-analyses in 1998 and 2021
- No trial of yohimbe supplements for ED

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Effect of bark supplements
- Half-life in people
- Results next to PDE5 drugs

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE
Not established

ROUTES STUDIED
Oral tablets (yohimbine hydrochloride) in trials

PHARMACOKINETICS
Not established

SOLD AS
Dietary supplement (yohimbe bark); no FDA-approved product

MONITORED IN TRIALS
Reported erection response, side effects

SPORT (WADA)
Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Not approved; OTC aphrodisiac claims barred
MHRA	Normally prescription-only (2016)
TGA	Prescription-only (Schedule 4)
WADA	Not listed

REFERENCES

1. NCCIH (NIH), Yohimbe: usefulness and safety, May 2025
2. eCFR, 21 CFR 310.528, OTC aphrodisiac drug products, Nov 2026
3. J Urol, Ernst & Pittler, yohimbine meta-analysis, Feb 1998

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